

Barnsley FC Fan Advisory Board

Meeting Minutes, Tuesday 9 June 2026

Held online via Microsoft Teams.

1. Attendees

Present

- Steve Brain, Chair of the FAB
- Phil Hall, FAB Member
- Claire Calton, FAB Member
- Martin Wilson, FAB Member (joined late)
- Dominic Wood, FAB Member (joined late, returning from travel)
- Paul Gallagher, FAB Member
- Jon Flatman, Chief Executive Officer, Barnsley FC
- John Bird, Head of Ticketing and Fan Engagement, Barnsley FC

Apologies

- Robin Harris, last-minute work commitment, sent advance notice.

Quorum

The full board, bar one apology, was in attendance, so the meeting was quorate and proceeded. The Chair noted he had to leave by 8pm, so members agreed to work through the agenda efficiently.

2. Minutes of the Previous Meeting and Matters Arising

No formal approval of the previous minutes was recorded at this meeting. Several matters arising from earlier meetings were carried into the agenda and Any Other Business, including the recurring question about hotel discounts for travelling supporters and ongoing stadium project works.

The Chair opened by congratulating JF on bringing Daniel back into the club.

3. FAB Structure, Vacancies and Communications

The Chair reported that he believed the Board's current term is up this year. (*This was clarified later - see below*) and that four vacancies had been advertised on the fan message board (BBS).

Only one response had been received: from a lifelong supporter, Peter Harrison, who lives in Bedford. Pete has worked in construction at a senior level and is now retired and keen to volunteer his time. (*His brother is Mike Harrison, the former England rugby union captain.*)

The Chair felt he would be a strong addition and proposed introducing him to the board by way of a Teams call.

PG questioned the wider plan given the Board's term being up and argued that any vacancies should be advertised more widely than just the fan message board.

JF advised holding off on advertising the vacancies more widely for now. His reasoning was that the Independent Football Regulator (IFR) is due to publish guidance shortly on the future of Fan Advisory Boards and fan engagement at clubs. That guidance would set out expectations on structure, how often meetings should be held, and a legal framework to

work from. JF stressed it would be "fit for purpose rather than a prescription" but would give the FAB firmer ground to stand on when going out to the fan base.

JB added that he had been on a call with the IFR specifically about fan engagement, where he explained what our FAB does. The IFR indicated they would publish information on fan engagement in the coming months, after which the FAB would have a clearer picture. The IFR will not consult with individual FABs until the back end of the year because they are stretched across all clubs, but they are happy to attend a future FAB meeting when invited.

CC asked what happens at the end of a member's term if no one comes forward to fill the position. DW recalled from the original memorandum of understanding that members were eligible for two terms. JB, reading from the terms of reference, confirmed the initial term is two years, with provision from 2026 onwards for up to three terms. JF explained that the articles could be changed if needed, but that consistency points to roughly three terms; serving four or more would start to look like an ownership situation. He noted the BFC FAB is not at that point yet.

Outcome: The board agreed to hold off on advertising the vacancies more widely until the IFR's July guidance is published. Pete Harrison would still be brought in, for continuity and to bolster numbers. PG volunteered to join the Chair on an introductory call with him.

4. Season Ticket Sales

JB reported strong season ticket sales. Tickets went on sale later than last year but were running at more than double the equivalent point twelve months ago and had been above last year's figures from week one.

JF confirmed season tickets are up on last year despite a price increase. He said the Club was delighted with the campaign, particularly given the season just gone. The Club typically sells around 900 season tickets after the early-bird deadline, so there was still work to do, but the early signs were very positive.

JF noted the club had spent less on "paid-for" marketing this year and leaned more on social media, though he cautioned that every season is different and sales are influenced by many factors. He congratulated JB and his team on the campaign, saying it could only be seen as a success.

5. Independent Football Regulator (IFR) Update

JF gave an update on the IFR, which is coming into statute. Key points:

- The IFR is fundamentally a risk assessor; there to assess the long-term sustainability of clubs.
- A significant amount of work is going into transparency around ownership, including a public record of who owners are and their holdings.
- The Owners' and Directors' test now sits with the IFR: any new appointment into ownership or a directorship has to be approved by them.
- Changes this month require approval for alterations to a club's crest, protecting heritage.
- Where a club's finances are deemed a risk, the IFR could in principle request that the club put up a bond. This has been raised at other clubs and is relevant context for supporters.
- Wider work includes the State of the Game report and connected debates about a fairer financial distribution across the EFL and Premier League.

JF said met with David Cogan of the IFR and found him very open and transparent. JB added that, on his fan-engagement call with the IFR, they were happy with what Barnsley are doing, saw no issues, and would come to a future meeting.

6. Cost Control (SCMP) and Player Trading

JF explained changes to the cost control rules (the Salary Cost Management Protocol, or SCMP), which came through last month and will be voted on by clubs. The headline change is that the contribution clubs can count is now straight equity at 50%, replacing the previous tapered arrangement (members referenced an earlier 60% figure). The aim is to reduce club losses and make clubs more sustainable, which links directly back to the IFR's purpose.

PG asked whether the change went far enough and whether there had been discussion of going further. Jon said views had varied: some clubs would have gone further, others not as far, and the agreed position was a compromise that could command a vote. He explained that the cost of recruitment is already biting, using the phrase that "a quid now costs you two quid", and that the full effect would not be seen until the end of next season.

The discussion moved on to player trading. JF explained that player sales become a more important and reliable way to generate revenue to invest into football spend, and that selling one player can be worth roughly the same as doubling season ticket revenue. MW and DW pressed on what this means for Barnsley's recruitment and the need to sell to survive. Jon agreed the club has to sell, but said it also has to sell well and from a position of strength, and that the model of developing players and selling them on remains central. He gave the example of a player in the building (referred to as Patrick Kelly) whose value had risen, noting that recruitment would look fundamentally different going forward.

7. Auracast and Audio Commentary for Disabled Supporters

PH reported back from an RNID hearing loss conference. He explained that Auracast, a newer audio-broadcast technology, is developing fast in the UK. All Apple phones and earbuds are now Auracast compatible, and there is a push for it to become standard in public spaces such as football stadiums and places of worship. PH said it is the coming thing and worth the club being aware of early. He knows a contact who could survey the stadium and advise exactly what would be needed.

MW raised the related issue of audio commentary for visually impaired supporters. The current Oakwell system is analogue, with a headset and receiver collected from the box office. He praised the quality of BFC commentary and the experience at other clubs and made the point that the commentator's quality matters as much as the equipment. JF agreed there are two separate questions: the quality of the commentary at Oakwell, and how to deliver it through better technology. He suggested putting JB in touch with PH's contact to explore options, possibly broadcasting from the disabled box. DW suggested a wired or fibre solution as an alternative.

Outcome: PH to send his contact's details to JB, who will follow up and explore Auracast and improved audio commentary provision.

8. Community Trust Grant

PH gave a brief update on a grant application connected to the Community Trust, on which he has been working with Kieran and James Cook. Around 20% of the funding had been approved so far, covering items such as activities for younger children, with a decision on the remainder expected before the end of June.

JF encouraged the board to publicise its involvement to the fan base, pointing out that being able to show fans the FAB had input into how money is spent is a clear justification for the importance of this FAB. He suggested PH chase the timeline, which he believed was quicker than the two weeks Phil had been quoted. PH & SB will pick this up.

9. EFL FAB Network

The Chair reported on the new English Football League FAB Network, an initiative bringing together fan groups from an estimated 25 to 30 EFL clubs. The inaugural meeting had been held online the week before, with the aim of building a national network and taking views on structure. The Chair gave the meeting a verbal account of Barnsley's FAB issues and challenges, emphasising the positive relationship it has with the Club.

Ticketing came up as the main challenge across several clubs. The Chair noted a range of experiences from the various club attendees, ranging from very poor to excellent.

In summary the view was that we should continue to attend, as it will give our FAB the opportunity to tap into best practice and avoid pitfalls experienced by other FABs across the EFL.

JF welcomed the initiative but cautioned against it becoming a "war stories" or self-help group where the most pessimistic voices dominate. He encouraged a focus on best practice, learning: "who is doing things well and how", rather than airing grievances. The Chair agreed and confirmed the first meeting had not in fact been dominated by complaints.

Outcome: The Chair to continue attending the network meetings. Continuity was felt to be valuable, but any FAB member could attend, including as an observer. PG advised that he would like to attend the next meeting.

10. Play-off Final Anniversary

The FAB discussed the anniversary of the play-off final at Cardiff and the related memories and content appearing on the club website. JF asked whether the FAB could lead on some of the commemoration. The Chair confirmed the FAB was happy to help, and PH raised the issue of looking ahead to next year. JF suggested speaking to Darren Hayes at the club to coordinate, with the FAB providing manpower and the club getting behind it.

Outcome: PH and the Chair to speak to Daz about the FAB taking on some of the anniversary content and activity.

11. Any Other Business

The Chair worked through a list of points raised by supporters via the fan message board and other channels.

Hotel discounts for travelling supporters. A supporter had again asked whether discounts were available for fans travelling from a distance who wanted to stay overnight. John Bird confirmed the club now has a deal in place offering 10% off a stay, with the information provided to away supporters. He would share the details and look to push it further.

Sanitary bins and products. A supporter had asked why there were not sanitary bins in all toilets, a point PH echoed. JB confirmed Barnsley were one of the first clubs to provide free sanitary products and are looking to reintroduce them. On bins, he and the Head of HR had walked round all the toilets to assess how many were needed; some toilets had bins and some did not, notices had been put up, and provision is being increased for next season. CC suggested also placing bins outside the toilets so that supporters who cannot get into a cubicle at half-time are catered for and welcomed the progress.

Paul Conway. The Chair asked whether former owner Paul Conway had been pursued by the club for any mismanagement. Jon Flatman indicated there was nothing to add: enough had been said, the relevant documentation between the parties and the EFL was a matter of record, and everything public is public. No further action was indicated.

Website and social media accuracy. The Chair raised inaccuracies in club website notifications and social media posts and asked what the checking process is. The trigger had

been the pre-season friendlies announcement, which carried confusing fixture dates. PH added an example of an incorrect match-result post. JF explained that errors happen at every club and even on major outlets, and that a full proofreading layer would roughly double the staff needed, for limited benefit. He drew a clear distinction, however: minor typos are one thing, but getting a fixture date wrong is a serious error the club should get right. On the Scarborough kick-off time specifically, JB clarified that Barnsley had it correct at 1pm; the discrepancy was on Scarborough's side. PG suggested using a tool to catch spelling and grammatical errors before posts go out. JF agreed to look into it.

Birds nesting at the stadium. In response to another fan question, DW and MW raised birds nesting on the concourse roof in the East Stand and the deterrents used to move them on.; JF agreed to look into it and respond.

Hand dryers. The Chair asked whether all hand dryers in the toilets are working, noting it was likely a general maintenance matter. JF agreed to investigate.

Toilet heating. CC noted that heating in some upstairs toilets had not seemed to be on towards the end of last season and asked whether there was an issue. JF agreed to check whether the heating is working as it should.

Audio summary of the meeting. PG confirmed he is producing an audio summary of the meeting and asked whether anything should be excluded. JF asked to review it before publication and to ensure it is presented as a summary rather than a full podcast of the meeting itself. PG confirmed it is an audio summary.

Stadium projects. PG asked for an update on outstanding stadium projects, including the Fan Zone and Redfern's Bar. JF explained the club is working through its final projects and assessing what budget remains. The floodlights are being replaced: the existing towers are coming to the end of their life, and the halogen lamps will be replaced with more efficient LED units installed at the top of the stands, improving light levels as well as cutting energy use. Work on the Box Office and surrounding area is also in hand, with the aim of completing the main works before the start of the season.

Pre-season fixtures and commentary. The Lincoln City fixture was confirmed for Saturday 1 August, kick-off 7pm. The Scarborough friendly kicks off at 1pm. MW confirmed arrangements for collecting his commentary headset from the box office as usual, noting the entrance has moved.

Introductions. The Chair advised that he had asked JF if Daniel Stendel might be able to attend a future FAB meeting once he was back at Oakwell to meet the FAB in person, so that the FAB could say hello and welcome him back. JF agreed this could be done, noting that DS will be back mid-June.

The Chair suggested dates after 15th June, into early July, and asked FAB Members to advise on their best dates in that period.

The Chair also asked whether JF could arrange for Neerav to introduce himself to the FAB.

12. Actions Log

Action	Owner	Deadline
Hold off advertising FAB vacancies more widely until IFR July guidance is published.	SB	After IFR July guidance

Action	Owner	Deadline
Arrange and hold introductory Teams call with prospective member Pete Harrison.	SB / PG	June 2026
Send Auracast/audio-commentary contact details to JB.	PH	As soon as possible
Follow up on Auracast and improved audio commentary, exploring broadcast from the disabled box.	JB	Ongoing
Chase Community Trust grant decision and publicise FAB involvement to fans	PH / SB (with Kieran/James Cook)	Before end of June 2026
Continue attending EFL FAB Network meetings; arrange member cover/observers as needed	SB / PG.	Ongoing
Speak to Daz about FAB leading on play-off final anniversary content	PH / SB	Ongoing
Share away-fan hotel discount details (10% off) and look to expand	JB	As soon as possible
Increase sanitary bin provision across toilets for next season; consider bins outside toilets	JB	Before next season
Look into a spelling/grammar checking tool for website and social media posts	JF	Ongoing
Investigate birds nesting on East Stand concourse roof and deterrents	JF	Ongoing
Check hand dryers and toilet heating are working	JF	Ongoing
Review PG's audio summary before publication	JF	Before publication
Arrange in-person introduction of Daniel Stendel and Neerav Parekh.	SB / JF	After 15 June - July 2026

These minutes are an official record of the Barnsley FC Fan Advisory Board meeting held on 9 June 2026. Supporters with questions or topics for a future meeting can email fab.supportertrust@barnsleyfc.co.uk or visit <https://fab.barnsleyfc.co.uk>.